CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Saturday, October 24, 2026 No. 213 11 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Kim Jong Un crossed into Dandong via the newly opened New Yalu River Bridge, his first confirmed China visit in over a year.
2. Kim met with Chinese Premier Li Qiang in Dandong and returned to North Korea the same day, per National Assembly Intelligence Committee readout.
3. Kim separately chaired a two-day Korean People's Army company commanders conference calling for a 'military revolution' and the world's strongest army.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,550.30	1,325.40	$116.72	39%	Today	2.50%
+0.3%	−0.0%	+3.1%	+2 pts Oct 13-15	public appearance	Oct 2026

01 | TOP STORIES

NK News / Reuters / Yonhap / Oct 24, China-Korea

Kim Jong Un makes unannounced visit to Dandong via new Yalu bridge, met Chinese Premier

Kim Jong Un crossed into China's Dandong via the newly opened New Yalu River Bridge on October 24, the ROK Unification Ministry confirmed, marking his first visit to China in over a year. The Presidential Office stated it was monitoring the situation closely, noting no official announcement from either side.

Democratic Party National Assembly Intelligence Committee member **Yun Geon-young** told SBS that Kim likely met with Chinese Premier Li Qiang and returned to North Korea the same day, with the visit timed to the October 25 anniversary of China's entry into the Korean War.

NK News / Reuters / Korea JoongAng Daily / Yonhap / Oct 24, DPRK

Kim Jong Un calls for 'military revolution' at KPA company commanders conference

Kim Jong Un oversaw the Third Meeting of Company Leaders of the Korean People's Army (KPA) in Pyongyang on October 22-23, calling for perfecting low-level leadership, improving training systems, and building the world's strongest armed forces, per the Korean Central News Agency (KCNA).

Kim delivered a speech framing the drive as a "military revolution" targeting unit-level command. The conference preceded his departure for Dandong, combining domestic military signaling with a diplomatic move toward Beijing.

Washington Post / Oct 24, DPRK

Seoul proposes military talks with Pyongyang to address border tensions; North Korea silent

South Korea's Ministry of National Defense proposed military-to-military talks with North Korea to resolve disputes over the Military Demarcation Line (MDL) and ease rising border tensions, per The Washington Post.

Yonhap reported North Korea had not responded by the following day. The proposal follows North Korea's laying of *960,000 mines* near the Demilitarized Zone since 2024, per Dong-A Ilbo, and Kim Yo Jong's ongoing border fortification inspections and loudspeaker warnings.

02 OVERNIGHT

Yonhap, China-Korea

Dandong imposed strict traffic and hotel controls three days before Kim's visit, Kyodo reports

Security controls and armored vehicles deployed around the항미원조 memorial.

SBS, DPRK

Lazarus Group exploiting PHP vulnerability to stage cyberattacks, per analysis

North Korean hacking group Lazarus observed exploiting a PHP programming language security flaw.

KEIA, US-Korea

KEI survey: 58% of Americans back South Korean nuclear-powered submarines, oppose nuclear weapons

2026 KEI poll; majority oppose Seoul acquiring independent nuclear warheads.

The Korea Herald, US-Korea

US Army activates Guam air defense battalion against North Korean and Chinese missile threats

Activation reported by Korea Herald; part of broader US Indo-Pacific force posture adjustments.

Singapore Economic Development Board (EDB), China-Korea

China, South Korea and Japan eyeing ASEAN clean energy market as US scales back

Three Northeast Asian economies positioning for ASEAN renewable investment amid US policy retreat.

03 STAT OF THE DAY

960,000

Mines North Korea has laid near DMZ since 2024

Dong-A Ilbo reports North Korea has laid 960,000 mines near the Demilitarized Zone since 2024, providing context for Seoul's proposed military talks and Kim Yo Jong's ongoing border fortification inspections.

Dong-A Ilbo (Dong-A Ilbo), Oct 24

04 PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

Public appearance: Kim Jong Un made an unannounced visit to Dandong, China, crossing the newly opened New Yalu River Bridge on October 24, and chaired the Third Meeting of Company Leaders of the Korean People's Army in Pyongyang on October 22-23.

No KCNA watch flag.

> *"military revolution"*
>
> **Kim Jong Un**, Kim Jong Un rallies junior commanders to build 'world's strongest' army

Bottom line: State media reported Kim's KPA commanders conference simultaneously with external confirmation of his surprise China visit, a dual signal combining domestic military mobilization messaging with an unannounced diplomatic move.

05 ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Saturday, October 24, 2026

PRESIDENTIAL OFFICE

Presidential Office spokesperson

Blue House says monitoring Kim's China visit closely; no official announcements from either side

The Presidential Office stated it was tracking Kim Jong Un's visit to Dandong 'with all possibilities in mind' and monitoring the situation closely, noting no official announcement had been made by either Beijing or Pyongyang. The statement was issued the same day the Unification Ministry confirmed the visit.

SBS

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Kim Hee-sang, G20 Sherpa

Korea-UK G20 Sherpa consultation held in Berlin on 2027-2028 summit continuity

G20 Sherpa **Kim Hee-sang** met UK G20 Sherpa Michael Ellam at the Berlin Global Dialogue on October 22, consulting on the 2027 (UK) and 2028 (South Korea) G20 presidencies and agreed to advance cooperation on energy supply chains and AI governance across the two cycles.

Primary Foreign Ministry

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Jo Ju-seong, Overseas Safety Planning Director

MOFA wraps 'Friends of Korea' security official exchange; 8 officials from 7 countries hosted

MOFA concluded its second 2026 overseas security official exchange program, hosting eight law enforcement and immigration officials from the Netherlands, Timor-Leste, Malaysia, Mexico, Guam (US), Vietnam, and Cambodia from October 19-24, including personnel who assisted ROK nationals during the 2026 North America World Cup.

Primary Foreign Ministry

PRIME MINISTER'S OFFICE

Han Seong-sook, Prime Minister

PM Han apologizes at Itaewon disaster 4th anniversary memorial; pledges investigation support and commemoration facilities

Prime Minister **Han Seong-sook** attended the 4th anniversary citizens' memorial for the October 29 Itaewon disaster at Seoul Plaza, bowing in apology on behalf of the government and pledging to support the ongoing special investigation committee and to fund a memorial foundation. She noted the victim toll has risen to 160 following the death of a merchant who was injured in rescue efforts in April 2026.

Newsis

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Intelligence Committee member confirms Kim's China meeting with Premier Li Qiang; day-trip assessment

National Assembly Intelligence Committee

Democratic Party National Assembly Intelligence Committee member Yun Geon-young told SBS that based on information from the National Intelligence Service, Kim Jong Un likely met with Chinese Premier Li Qiang during his Dandong visit and returned to North Korea the same day. The NIS briefed the committee that Kim's death rumors circulating on social media were false.

Committee proposes disqualification motion against broadcaster Lee Jin-suk; ruling-opposition clash

National Assembly Science and Technology Committee

The National Assembly Science and Technology Information Broadcasting and Communications Committee tabled a motion to disqualify broadcaster Lee Jin-suk from a parliamentary audit hearing, with the People Power Party (PPP) objecting, calling it 'Democratic Party dictatorship.' The dispute reflects ongoing inter-party friction in the ongoing national audit session.

06 | US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

Changed since last issue: Steel & Aluminum, Automobiles & Auto Parts, Civil Aircraft & Parts.

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and automobiles at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff. The Section 301 investigation launched March 11, 2026 is now the primary prospective legal vehicle for new tariffs.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding (MASGA), $200B strategic sectors, $100B energy purchases; no official drawdown figure reported to date.

07 | CAPITOL HILL

Congress.gov, House, Legislation, H.R.9963

North Korean FAKER Act text published in 119th Congress

The text of H.R.9963, the North Korean FAKER Act, has been published on Congress.gov as part of the 119th Congress (2025-2026). The bill addresses fraudulent activities by North Korean workers or agents, per the bill title.

The Hill, Legislation

Treasury proposes curbs on high-tech investment in China, Russia, North Korea

The US Treasury Department has proposed rules curbing American high-technology investments in China, Russia, and North Korea, per The Hill. The proposed outbound investment screening rules would affect semiconductors, artificial intelligence, and other strategic technologies.

08 NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Foreign Ministry, Japan-Korea, Primary

FM Cho Hyun calls for expanded Japan-Korea supply chain and advanced industry cooperation at business council

Foreign Minister **Cho Hyun**, in remarks read by Deputy FM Kim Jin-a at the 33rd Japan-Korea Business Council dinner, said bilateral relations have reached the most stable development track since the Lee Jae-myung government took office, citing shuttle diplomacy and cooperation in supply chains, energy, and advanced industries. The council, launched in 1982, met under the theme 'New Horizon of Korea-Japan Economic Cooperation: Prelude to a New 60 Years.'

The Washington Post, China-Korea

China's role under scrutiny as Kim's Dandong visit raises questions about mediation and DPRK influence

Yonhap reported that the November Shenzhen Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) summit has fueled speculation about a possible North Korea-US leaders meeting, with Kim's China visit potentially serving as preparatory groundwork. Analysts quoted by Yonhap said the visit may reinforce North Korea-China 'blood alliance' optics rather than signal substantive diplomatic movement.

NK News, China-Korea

Chinese veterans affairs delegation visits Pyongyang ahead of October 25 Korean War anniversary

A delegation from China's veterans affairs ministry arrived in Pyongyang, per NK News, ahead of the October 25 anniversary of the Chinese People's Volunteer Army's entry into the Korean War, the occasion the ROK Unification Ministry cited as the likely trigger for Kim's Dandong visit. The delegation's presence underlines the political choreography around the anniversary.

09 KOREA AND THE WORLD

Chosun Ilbo, Ukraine, Diplomacy

Lee government faces dilemma over Ukraine's push to transfer North Korean prisoners of war

The Lee Jae-myung government is navigating a diplomatic dilemma as Ukraine presses Seoul to accept or facilitate the transfer of North Korean soldiers captured on the Russian front, per Chosun Ilbo. Seoul's response has implications for its relationship with both Kyiv and Pyongyang, and for its broader positioning on the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

Vietnam Investment Review - VIR, Southeast Asia, Trade

Vietnam-South Korea trade on track to pass $100 billion milestone, diplomat says

A Vietnamese diplomat said bilateral trade with South Korea is set to surpass a historic $100 billion milestone, per Vietnam Investment Review. Vietnam is one of South Korea's largest trading partners in Southeast Asia and a major destination for Korean manufacturing investment.

Defensemirror, Europe, Defense exports

Poland to integrate Norwegian remote weapon systems onto South Korean-origin K2 tanks

Poland announced it will integrate Norwegian remote weapon systems onto K2 tanks of South Korean origin in its fleet, per Defensemirror. The integration deepens the multi-country technology layering on Korea's largest European defense export platform.

10 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

SBS

SK Hynix halts Solidigm US IPO after Seoul authorities flag dual-listing concerns

SK Hynix announced it will suspend the US stock market listing of its NAND subsidiary Solidigm following concerns raised by Seoul authorities about a parent-subsidiary dual-listing overhang. SK Hynix shares rose more than 4% on the announcement.

SK Hynix Solidigm

BOK Governor: return to ultra-low rates 'difficult'; warns against relying on semiconductor tax revenue

Bank of Korea (BOK) Governor Shin Hyun-song stated at parliamentary audit hearings that a return to the ultra-low interest rate environment seen before the pandemic is 'difficult,' given expectations of a high-growth, high-rate environment. He separately warned the government not to expand fiscal spending premised on semiconductor tax revenue alone.

Bank of Korea

Newsis

Government to ease diesel export restrictions as domestic sales fall 7.6%

South Korea's government announced it will loosen restrictions on diesel exports after domestic diesel sales fell 7.6%, reflecting a shift toward electric vehicles and reduced industrial demand. The policy adjustment comes as global oil prices rise sharply on Middle East tensions.

11 UPCOMING

OCT 25 — **China's Korean War entry anniversary, DPRK-China diplomatic context**

October 25 is the anniversary of the Chinese People's Volunteer Army's entry into the Korean War; the ROK Unification Ministry cited it as the likely occasion for Kim Jong Un's October 24 Dandong visit.

OCT 26 — **China Communist Party plenum opens, DPRK diplomacy backdrop**

China's Communist Party plenum runs October 26-29, per Reuters; the timing overlaps with Kim Jong Un's China visit and possible North Korea-China diplomatic signaling ahead of November APEC.

OCT 29 — **Itaewon disaster 4th anniversary**

The 4th anniversary of the October 29 Itaewon crowd crush falls this week; Prime Minister Han Seong-sook attended an advance memorial on October 24 and pledged government support for the special investigation committee and commemoration facilities.

OCT 30 — **South Korea Q3 GDP data release due next week**

Yonhap previews next week's key economic data including the third-quarter GDP growth rate and September industrial activity figures, which will inform BOK rate deliberations.

NOV 1 — **APEC leaders summit, Shenzhen; Kim-Trump meeting speculation**

The APEC leaders summit in Shenzhen is cited by Yonhap as a focal point for speculation about a possible North Korea-US meeting, with Kim Jong Un's China visit viewed by some analysts as preparatory to that diplomatic window.

12 ANALYSIS

COMMENTARY

North Korea may be the biggest winner of Russia's war in Ukraine. The piece argues North Korea has accrued disproportionate strategic gains from its Russia partnership, including battlefield experience for Korean People's Army units deployed to Russia and reverse technology transfer. The author situates these gains within a broader Indo-Pacific security threat calculus. The analysis complements the CSIS Korea Chair's ongoing NK-Russia Axis research. (Rick Hoehne, Atlantic Council, Atlantic Council)

Ukraine and South Korea's Diplomatic Dispute Deepens | State of Play. The CSIS State of Play examines the growing diplomatic rift between South Korea and Ukraine over the disposition of North Korean soldiers captured on the Russian front. The piece maps Seoul's dilemma: engaging Kyiv risks escalating North Korea, while refusing risks straining the Ukraine relationship and European allies. The analysis is directly relevant to today's Chosun Ilbo reporting on the Lee government's POW dilemma. (CSIS, CSIS)

13 PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

39%

+2 pts vs Oct 6-8
Gallup Korea
October 13-15, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 6 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
36%	27%	29%

Gallup Korea publishes weekly; this reading is 1 week old (October 13-15, 2026).

14 THE WIRE

ROK POLITICS

Chosun Ilbo

Democratic Party advances chief justice probe amid impeachment calls

South Korea's Democratic Party advanced proceedings to investigate the chief justice, with impeachment calls emerging, per Chosun Ilbo. The move extends a pattern of legislative pressure on the judiciary under the Lee Jae-myung government.

DPRK

Dong-A Ilbo

North Korea has laid 960,000 mines near DMZ since 2024

North Korea has laid 960,000 mines near the Demilitarized Zone since 2024, per Dong-A Ilbo, providing context for Seoul's proposal for military talks and the ongoing inter-Korean tension. The figure accompanies reporting on Kim Yo Jong's border fortification inspections and loudspeaker threat deadline.

NK News

North Korean IT infiltration of ROK organizations exposes security gaps

Dong-A Ilbo reports North Korean information technology workers infiltrated South Korean organizations by falsifying identities, with police investigating the case; the earlier Yonhap report confirmed police opened an investigation. The case follows Australia's sanctioning of North Koreans for fraudulent IT work and cybercrime reported earlier this week.

38 North

38 North: Satellite imagery shows DPRK rural transformation under 20x10 development plan

38 North's Martyn Williams uses satellite imagery to document North Korea's ongoing rural construction drive under Kim Jong Un's 20x10 regional development plan, showing visible changes across the countryside. The analysis provides a baseline against which future imagery can measure economic policy implementation.

15 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

ACTIVITY, RISING

Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

38 North satellite imagery from October 16 confirms trucks traversing the New Yalu River (DPRK-Friendship) Bridge one day after the October 15 official opening, marking the start of commercial vehicle traffic. Daily NK reports customs delays leaving truck drivers waiting more than three hours. North Korea-China trade reached $299M in September 2026, the second-highest monthly total in 2026. Kim Jong Un crossed the New Yalu River Bridge on October 24 during his unannounced visit to Dandong, the first use of the bridge by the North Korean leader, nine days after its official opening.

imagery as of 2026-10-24

10 other monitored sites: no new reporting since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 213

TOMORROW

China's Korean War entry anniversary, DPRK-China diplomatic context

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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